engines, armoured vehicles, submarines and wireless sets. No expert felt safe in his presence.'[14]

Most importantly, however, he laid the foundations for India's own defence industries to make the country less dependent on imports and he restructured much of India's military command system, which under his tutelage came to be based on merit rather than seniority within the ranks. Menon was also the mastermind behind the annexation of the former Portuguese colony of Goa in 1961. In 1957, he set the record for the longest speech before the UN Security Council in New York. For eight hours, he defended India's right to sovereignty over Kashmir against Pakistan's claims to the same. Five years after he was forced out of the government, he left the ruling Congress Party and stood for several elections as an independent candidate. When he died at the age of 78 in 1974, the then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi stated that 'a volcano is extinct'.[15]

The next head to roll was that of General Pran Nath Thapar, Chief of Army Staff. On 18 November 1962, he flew back from Tezpur to Delhi, and went straight to Nehru's residence. Thapar told the prime minister that he was willing to resign. He said it was not his fault that the Indian Army had been routed in the Himalayas, but, as a professional soldier, he assumed responsibility for the disaster. Nehru said that he would consider it and, the following day, accepted Thapar's offer. Thapar then submitted a formal request for early retirement, which was granted.

Thapar was born in the western part of Punjab, which now belongs to Pakistan, and went to school in Lahore. Like so many other army officers of his generation, he was educated at Britain's Royal Military College at Sandhurst. He saw action in Myanmar, the Middle East, and Italy during World War II and later became Director of Military Operations and Intelligence. Thapar had a distinguished military career, and became army chief in May 1961. After his resignation from the military, he served for five years as India's ambassador to Afghanistan.

Thapar's successor as the Chief of Army Staff, General Jayanto Nath Chaudhury, a Bengali, was also a Sandhurst graduate who had taken part in the 'Burma Campaign', the British counteroffensive in Myanmar to recover the colony from the Japanese. Chaudhury had served as army chief for only